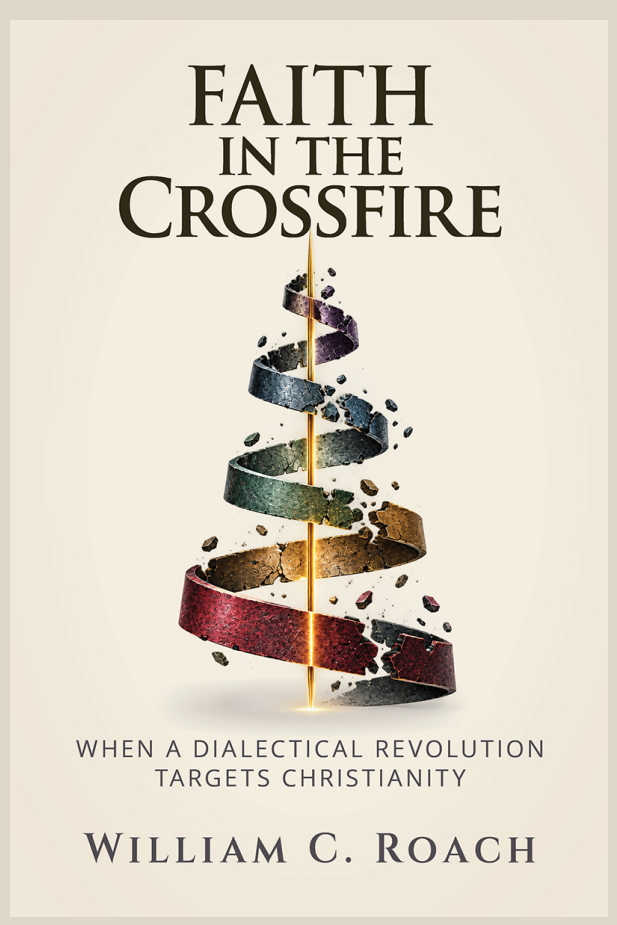
A COMPANION FOR GROUP DISCUSSION



Small Group Study Guide

Eight conversations on truth, Scripture, and Christian faith

WILLIAM C. ROACH

FOR HIGH SCHOOL, COLLEGE, AND ADULT GROUPS

How to use this guide

Read the assigned chapter before each meeting. The questions are designed for a group conversation, not a test. Bring your Bible and a copy of the book. Several chapters are substantial; begin reading early and take notes as you go.

A one-hour meeting

5 minutes: Welcome, opening question, and prayer.

10 minutes: Read the suggested Bible passages and recap the chapter.

30 minutes: Discuss the numbered questions; choose the ones most useful to your group.

10 minutes: Work through the activity together.

5 minutes: Share the closing reflection and pray.

For the leader

Each session has twelve questions. Choose five or six in advance that cover the chapter's main themes; the rest can be used for individual reflection or a longer meeting. Invite people to explain the author's argument in their own words and point to the chapter. Encourage thoughtful disagreement and distinguish a critique of ideas from judgments about people. Let anyone pass on a question.

The suggested Scriptures are starting points for discussion, not an answer key. Encourage the group to read each passage in context. The book's interpretations and claims can be examined together with care.

Before each meeting

As you read, note one idea you understand, one question you have, and one passage you would like to discuss. Use the lines beneath each question for your answers and notes. Chapter 7 is especially long; begin it early or agree to split its reading across the preceding weeks. The meeting is still planned for one hour.

A few terms to know

These working definitions will help start the conversation. Consult the book for the author's fuller use of each term.

Metaphysics: The study of what is real and the basic nature of reality.

Epistemology: The study of knowledge: what we can know, and how we can know it.

Hermeneutics: The study and practice of interpretation, including how readers understand texts.

Classical realism: The view that reality exists independently of our minds and can be known, although our knowledge is limited and sometimes mistaken.

Dialectic: A term with different meanings in different thinkers; in this study, examine how the author describes conflict and change in each context.

Theory: In the book's discussion of Marxism, the ideas and analysis used to interpret society, particularly in terms of power, oppression, and liberation. Theory seeks to shape a person's consciousness and provides a framework for action.

Praxis: The practical application of theory through criticism and action intended to transform people and society. In the Marxist framework discussed in the book, praxis includes raising consciousness and pursuing revolutionary change; theory and praxis are distinguishable but closely connected.

Logos: A Greek term translated "Word"; John 1 identifies the eternal Word with Jesus Christ.

Revelation: God's making Himself known. General revelation is associated with creation; special revelation includes God's particular self-disclosure in Scripture and in Christ.

Proposition: A statement that makes a claim which can be true or false; propositional revelation communicates truth in meaningful statements.

Figures to know

These brief introductions identify people discussed in the book. The chapter references indicate where to begin; use the book for the author's fuller account and evaluation. Figures are listed alphabetically by last name.

Theodor W. Adorno: Frankfurt School philosopher who analyzed modern culture and social domination, including with Horkheimer (chapter 2).

Saul Alinsky: Community organizer and author of Rules for Radicals; Roach discusses his methods for organizing and social change (chapter 2).

Karl Barth: Swiss theologian associated with dialectical theology and neo-orthodoxy; Roach examines his account of revelation and Scripture (chapter 4).

Derrick Bell: Legal scholar and an important figure in critical race theory; the book discusses his analysis of race and law (chapter 2).

Angela Davis: Scholar and activist who studied with Marcuse; Roach discusses her political commitments and educational activism (chapter 2).

Paulo Freire: Brazilian educator known for a pedagogy connecting education, critical consciousness, and social transformation (chapter 2).

Hans-Georg Gadamer: Philosopher of hermeneutics who examined the role of history and tradition in understanding (chapter 3).

Norman L. Geisler: Evangelical philosopher and apologist whose classical realism and defense of reason, revelation, and biblical inerrancy inform Roach's response (especially chapters 4–7).

Antonio Gramsci: Italian Marxist thinker known for cultural hegemony and the struggle for influence within civil society (chapter 2).

G. W. F. Hegel: German philosopher whose account of dialectical development is central to Roach's discussion of modern thought (chapters 3–4).

Martin Heidegger: German philosopher whose account of human existence and understanding is discussed in the chapter on hermeneutics (chapter 3).

Carl F. H. Henry: Evangelical theologian whose fifteen theses articulate a doctrine of divine revelation and the authority of Scripture (chapter 7).

Max Horkheimer: Frankfurt School philosopher who helped develop critical theory and its critique of social institutions (chapter 2).

Søren Kierkegaard: Danish thinker whose account of faith, subjectivity, and paradox Roach contrasts with Hegel's approach (chapter 4).

C. S. Lewis: Christian writer and apologist. Roach draws on The Screwtape Letters to illustrate subtle deception and the reclassification of ideas (chapter 1).

James Lindsay: Contemporary writer and critic of critical theories. Roach engages Lindsay's analysis of theory and praxis and his interpretation of Marxism as a religious project (chapter 2).

Herbert Marcuse: Frankfurt School philosopher who developed a critique of advanced industrial society and influenced the New Left (chapter 2).

Karl Marx: German philosopher and social theorist associated with historical materialism, class struggle, and communist revolution (chapters 2–3).

Francis Schaeffer: Evangelical apologist who defended “true truth” and warned against the church’s accommodation to the surrounding culture (especially chapters 1, 5, 6, and 8).

Friedrich Schleiermacher: Theologian and interpreter associated with developments in hermeneutics, including the relationship between a text’s parts and its whole (chapter 3).

As you read

Ask what each figure believed, how Roach uses or critiques that work, and how each person’s contribution differs from those of the others. A shared term does not necessarily mean that two thinkers use it in the same way.

SESSION 1

I Don’t Want to Talk About Politics

Read: Chapter 1, pp. 21–43 | Meeting: 60 minutes

Purpose: Distinguish political labels from the deeper questions of truth and authority.

Opening: What is one conversation about faith and culture that people find difficult to have? Why?

Scripture and recap: Read Acts 20:28–31; Colossians 2:8. Briefly summarize the chapter and share a question from your reading.

DISCUSSION | 30 MINUTES

1. What was Operation Greif? Why does Roach use it to illustrate ideas entering Christian communities under familiar appearances?

2. How does C. S. Lewis portray deception in The Screwtape Letters? How does Roach apply this insight to reclassifying theological disagreements as politics?

3. Why might a church avoid becoming a political organization yet still address controversial theological and ethical questions?

4. Explain the chapter’s three senses of “secular”: the temporal realm, an allegedly nonreligious public space, and changed conditions of belief.

5. How does the third sense help explain the challenges of Christian belief today? How is it different from the other two?

6. What does Schaeffer mean by “true truth,” and why does Roach think this matters to the church?

7. How can changing the meaning of a word or category affect a discussion before anyone examines the argument?

8. What does the discussion of Gnosticism suggest about special knowledge, Scripture, and the incarnation?

9. How do the examples from church history distinguish a theological question from an ordinary disagreement over political policy?

10. What responsibilities does Acts 20:27–31 give church leaders? How can a church fulfill them without confusing the gospel with party loyalty?

11. What evidence would help determine whether a teaching conflicts with Christianity rather than simply being unfamiliar?

12. How might Christians speak about a contested moral issue with both biblical conviction and respect for their neighbors?

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE | 10 MINUTES

A friend says, “Religion is private, so Christians should never discuss public issues.” How could you respond respectfully, using one idea from the chapter?

REFLECT AND PRAY | 5 MINUTES

What is one habit that would help you listen carefully and test a claim before sharing it? Close by praying for wisdom, love, and faithfulness.

SESSION 2

Faith and Praxis

Read: Chapter 2, pp. 44–81 | Meeting: 60 minutes

Purpose: Explain how beliefs shape action and examine the author’s account of revolutionary thought.

Opening: Name a belief that can affect how a person acts at school, work, or church.

Scripture and recap: Read Romans 12:1–2; Colossians 2:8. Briefly summarize the chapter and share a question from your reading.

DISCUSSION | 30 MINUTES

1. Explain theory and praxis. According to Roach, how do ideas shape action, and how can action form consciousness?

2. Who was Karl Marx? Explain class conflict, alienation, and revolution as the chapter presents them.

3. What does Antonio Gramsci mean by cultural hegemony, and why does the chapter say institutions matter to social change?

4. Who were Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno? How does Roach connect Frankfurt School critical theory with the critique of culture?

5. How does Herbert Marcuse adapt Marxist ideas to an affluent society? What role does he assign to revolutionary consciousness and the New Left?

6. Identify Angela Davis, Derrick Bell, Saul Alinsky, and Paulo Freire. What distinct contribution or method does Roach associate with each?

7. Why do Roach and James Lindsay describe Marxism in religious or theological terms? What does this comparison add to an economic analysis?

8. In Lindsay's interpretation, what corresponds to a "fall" in Marxism? Compare alienation and private property with the biblical account of sin.

9. How does the proposed "salvation" through revolutionary transformation differ from the Christian gospel of redemption in Jesus Christ?

10. What is a hermeneutics of suspicion? How does Roach connect it with consciousness-raising and social action?

11. How does Roach explain the movement from economic class to other categories of social conflict? Identify an example and consider the evidence.

12. Compare the chapter's account of human transformation with Romans 12:1–2. What differs about the problem, the means, and the desired end?

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE | 10 MINUTES

Choose a claim or campaign mentioned in the chapter. Identify an underlying belief, a proposed action, and one question you would ask before drawing a conclusion.

REFLECT AND PRAY | 5 MINUTES

How can your actions this week reflect what you believe about the value of other people? Close by praying for wisdom, love, and faithfulness.

SESSION 3

As Above, So Below

Read: Chapter 3, pp. 82–138 | Meeting: 60 minutes

Purpose: Trace the author's account of dialectical thought and its influence on interpretation.

Opening: When two people use the same word but mean different things, what problems can follow?

Scripture and recap: Read Genesis 1:26–27; 2 Timothy 2:15. Briefly summarize the chapter and share a question from your reading.

DISCUSSION | 30 MINUTES

1. What does "as above, so below" express in the book's discussion of Hermeticism? Why does Roach consider its view of reality important?

2. How does Roach describe dialectical movement in Hegel? What roles do contradiction, development, and synthesis play in his account?

3. Why does the chapter caution that the familiar thesis-antithesis-synthesis formula does not capture every nuance of Hegel's own method?

4. How does Marx adapt Hegel's dialectic? Compare their respective emphases on ideas and material or economic conditions.

5. How does the book describe the adaptation of dialectical conflict from economic class to social and cultural categories?

6. What does Schleiermacher contribute to the hermeneutical circle? How does his account of grammatical and psychological interpretation work?

7. How does Roach compare Schleiermacher’s approach to Hegel’s dialectic? Identify both a similarity and a difference.

8. How does Heidegger shift hermeneutics toward human existence and the conditions of understanding? Why does Roach think that shift matters?

9. How does Gadamer develop the discussion of understanding? What questions does he raise about history, the reader, and the text?

10. Choose a figure in the chapter and trace the connection between that figure’s view of reality, knowledge, and interpretation.

11. How does an author’s intended meaning differ from a reader’s application of a text? Use a biblical passage to explain.

12. Where does Roach see a difference in kind between classical evangelical interpretation and the approaches he critiques?

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE | 10 MINUTES

A group reads a Bible passage and reaches different conclusions. What steps could help them consider its words, context, and author’s intended meaning?

REFLECT AND PRAY | 5 MINUTES

What is one question you can ask to understand someone’s meaning before disagreeing? Close by praying for wisdom, love, and faithfulness.

SESSION 4

Heaven’s Logic, Earth’s Revolution

Read: Chapter 4, pp. 139–198 | Meeting: 60 minutes

Purpose: Explore the chapter’s historical argument and its implications for theology and ethics.

Opening: Why can an idea taught in a classroom eventually matter to everyday life?

Scripture and recap: Read Romans 12:2; 1 John 4:1. Briefly summarize the chapter and share a question from your reading.

DISCUSSION | 30 MINUTES

1. What does Roach mean by psychological warfare or worldview warfare? How might fear, isolation, and pressure to conform affect public discussion?

2. How does the chapter use the concepts of pathocracy and the weaponization of loneliness? What examples does it provide?

3. What does “liquid modernity” describe, and how does Roach relate uncertainty and instability to the possibility of manipulation?

4. Compare Hegel’s developmental dialectic with Kierkegaard’s emphasis on paradox and subjectivity. What theological consequences does Roach identify?

5. How does Roach describe Karl Barth’s approach to revelation and Scripture? How does he contrast it with a classical evangelical account?

6. Choose a theological movement discussed in the chapter. How does its method affect its account of knowledge, Scripture, or doctrine?

7. How does Roach argue that dialectical assumptions can be adopted in different settings, including those that use Christian language?

8. What is the difference between a historical influence and a superficial resemblance? What evidence does the chapter offer for a significant connection?

9. How does Norman Geisler help explain the effect of a philosophical method on theology? Illustrate your answer with a doctrine discussed in the chapter.

10. How does Francis Schaeffer’s concern about evangelical accommodation illuminate the chapter’s argument?

11. Can two groups use similar methods while disagreeing in other respects? Compare examples from the chapter without treating the groups as identical.

12. How can Christians resist manipulation and test claims without becoming suspicious of everyone with whom they disagree?

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE | 10 MINUTES

Select one example from the chapter. Trace its assumptions about truth to a possible conclusion about doctrine or ethical practice. Where does the group agree or have questions?

REFLECT AND PRAY | 5 MINUTES

What would it look like to pursue both clarity and kindness in a difficult discussion? Close by praying for wisdom, love, and faithfulness.

SESSION 5

A Brief But Necessary Interlude

Read: Chapter 5, pp. 199–204 | Meeting: 60 minutes

Purpose: Review the first half and prepare for the constructive Christian response.

Opening: What is one idea from the first four chapters you understand better now?

Scripture and recap: Read Colossians 2:6–8; 1 Thessalonians 5:21. Briefly summarize the chapter and share a question from your reading.

DISCUSSION | 30 MINUTES

1. Summarize the central argument of the first four chapters in your own words.

2. What relationship does Roach trace among metaphysics, epistemology, hermeneutics, doctrine, and ethics?

3. What does the author mean by a difference of kind between the underlying approaches he compares?

4. Choose a figure from the first part and explain how that figure’s method affects a theological or cultural conclusion.

5. Which concepts in the first half require clarification? Identify a passage in the book that helps explain one of them.

6. How do Schaeffer, Geisler, and Henry represent the classical evangelical commitments Roach wants to recover?

7. Why is a critique of another system incomplete without a positive account of truth and revelation?

8. How does the author distinguish the influence of a method from deliberate agreement with every thinker associated with it?

9. What is the strongest question you would raise about the argument so far? What evidence would help you answer it?

10. What should a Christian account explain about God, creation, human reason, and Scripture?

11. Read Colossians 2:6–8. How does the passage connect Christian growth with discernment?

12. What question do you most want the second half of the book to answer?

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE | 10 MINUTES

As a group, write a two-sentence summary of the argument so far. Then list two questions you hope the rest of the book answers.

REFLECT AND PRAY | 5 MINUTES

What would you like to understand more clearly during the remaining sessions? Close by praying for wisdom, love, and faithfulness.

SESSION 6

Reason and Rationality

Read: Chapter 6, pp. 205–244 | Meeting: 60 minutes

Purpose: Explain classical realism, truth, and the role of reason in the Christian life.

Opening: Can you think of a time when discovering a fact required you to change your mind?

Scripture and recap: Read Psalm 19:1–4; Romans 1:19–20. Briefly summarize the chapter and share a question from your reading.

DISCUSSION | 30 MINUTES

1. What is classical realism? Explain the difference between reality existing independently of our minds and our ability to know it.

2. What does it mean to say that truth corresponds to reality? Give an example and distinguish a true claim from confidence in it.

3. How do the senses and reason contribute to knowledge in Roach’s account? What limits does human knowledge have?

4. What are first principles of reasoning? Explain one discussed in the chapter and why it matters to Christian apologetics.

5. How does Roach describe faith and reason? Why does he reject the idea that Christian faith requires abandoning reason?

6. How does reason relate to divine revelation? What can reason do to recognize, understand, or defend revelation, and what must God make known?

7. What is the difference between general and special revelation? How do they relate in a Christian account of knowledge?

8. How does Norman Geisler's classical apologetics help explain the relationship among God's existence, reason, and Scripture?

9. How does Schaeffer's "true truth" support the claim that Christianity speaks about real events and the real world?

10. What does it mean to speak analogically about God? How can human language speak truly of God without comprehending Him exhaustively?

11. Compare classical realism with a different account of knowledge discussed in the chapter. Where does Roach locate the decisive difference?

12. How can a commitment to objective truth encourage both confidence and humility when interpreting evidence or Scripture?

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE | 10 MINUTES

A friend says, “That may be true for you, but it isn’t true for me.” Discuss a respectful way to distinguish a personal preference from a claim about reality.

REFLECT AND PRAY | 5 MINUTES

How can a commitment to truth encourage both confidence and a willingness to be corrected? Close by praying for wisdom, love, and faithfulness.

SESSION 7

Unveiling the Logos

Read: Chapter 7, pp. 245–325 | Meeting: 60 minutes

Purpose: Discuss the Logos, God’s revelation, and the authority of Scripture.

Opening: What difference does it make to a relationship when a person speaks clearly and truthfully?

Scripture and recap: Read John 1:1–18; 2 Timothy 3:14–17. Briefly summarize the chapter and share a question from your reading.

DISCUSSION | 30 MINUTES

1. According to John 1:1–18, who is the Logos? How are creation, incarnation, and God’s self-disclosure connected in Christ?

2. Why does Roach place the personal Logos at the center of his response to dialectical accounts of reality and revelation?

3. Consider Henry’s theses 1–3. Who initiates revelation, why does God reveal Himself, and how can God be truly known without being exhaustively known?

4. Consider theses 4–6. What do they say about the unity, divine determination, and personal character of revelation?

5. Consider theses 7–9. How do general revelation, God’s redemptive acts, Jesus Christ, and the eternal Logos relate to one another?

6. Consider theses 10–11. What is rational, conceptual-verbal revelation, and what role does Scripture play in communicating divine truth?

7. Consider theses 12–13. How does Henry distinguish the Spirit’s work in inspiring Scripture, illuminating it, and enabling saving reception?

8. Consider theses 14–15. What roles do the church and God’s final revelation play in Henry’s account?

9. Choose one of the fifteen theses and explain how Roach contrasts it with a dialectical, mystical, or non-cognitive approach discussed in the book.

10. How does Henry’s account of a personal God who freely speaks differ from Roach’s description of Hegel’s view of divine development in history?

11. Why does propositional revelation matter? Can God communicate truth in words while also making Himself personally known?

12. How do Henry, Geisler, and Schaeffer contribute to the classical evangelical defense of revelation and biblical authority in this book?

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE | 10 MINUTES

A friend says, “The Bible can mean whatever each reader feels it means.” How would you respond while acknowledging that readers may apply a passage in different situations?

REFLECT AND PRAY | 5 MINUTES

Choose one passage of Scripture to read carefully this week, paying attention to its context and intended meaning. Close by praying for wisdom, love, and faithfulness.

SESSION 8

The Christian Logos in a Dialectical Age

Read: Chapter 8, pp. 326–354 | Meeting: 60 minutes

Purpose: Consider how the book's argument shapes faithful, loving Christian life.

Opening: Who has helped you see that conviction and kindness can go together?

Scripture and recap: Read John 1:14–18; 1 Peter 3:15–16. Briefly summarize the chapter and share a question from your reading.

DISCUSSION | 30 MINUTES

1. Identify a current question facing your church, school, or community. What assumptions about truth, knowledge, or human nature lie beneath it?

2. Choose a case study from the chapter. Trace Roach's argument from the ideas he identifies to their practical consequences.

3. Using the account of truth as correspondence, how would you evaluate a claim on social media before sharing it?

4. How might a Christian apply the book's account of human beings as God's creatures to a question about technology or transhumanism?

5. A group member says a biblical text means whatever a reader experiences. How could you discuss authorial intent, context, and application respectfully?

6. How can a church address a moral question labeled “political” without treating the church as a political party?

7. How can we recognize a genuinely unjust situation while carefully examining the assumptions behind a proposed remedy?

8. How can a Christian respond to pressure, isolation, or fear without adopting manipulation or intimidation in return?

9. What does the Logos teach us about the connection between truth and the dignity of people with whom we disagree?

10. How could Schaeffer’s concern for truth and spiritual life shape the way your group discusses a difficult issue?

11. What would it look like to practice the gentleness and respect of 1 Peter 3:15–16 while holding firm convictions?

12. Name one concrete practice your group can adopt to pursue truth, serve neighbors, and remain faithful to Christ.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE | 10 MINUTES

Imagine a conversation with a friend who disagrees strongly with you. Practice stating your conviction, asking a sincere question, and summarizing the friend's view fairly.

REFLECT AND PRAY | 5 MINUTES

What is one way your group can continue to learn, serve, or encourage one another after this study? Close by praying for wisdom, love, and faithfulness.